I was probably one of the less obsessive kids. My friend Trax, for instance, had always been eccentric and seemed to suffer some kind of anxiety disorder. He hated to travel, rarely came to the city and once made reference to seeing a psychiatrist. But I have often found that the most interesting people are a little unusual, and Trax was both.

Hacking was a way for us to connect with other kids who didn't feel like hostages to normality. We wanted to go our own way and we had an instinct for questioning authority. In my case, I was born into that instinct. We were born into a permissive society, but our generation was perhaps more questioning of what permission meant. We weren't into '60s psychobabble about freedom – neither were my parents, who always felt the hippies were appallingly apolitical – and what we wanted to do was not protest abusive power but unseat it. If we were at all subversive, it was the kind of subversion that worked from the inside. We had the same mindset as the boys who were running the computer systems. We knew the language and had cracked their codes. The question would increasingly become one of following the inevitable, following the logic of what we had discovered and seeing how it held society to account. Around the time of the Australian bicentenary, 1988, there was a new confidence, a new abundance of home computers, a new vibrancy in popular culture, and a sense among my kind that the military–industrial complex of bombing people and buying stuff should be subverted. We grew up fast and made ready for trouble. We were already being targeted by the Bureau.

It is probably right to say I was more political than many of my friends. I had always believed, and still believe, that oppressive forces draw much of their strength from their ability to wield their power in secret. It wasn't long before I realised, from my experience inside the systems, that the 'clandestine' zone might be the right place to confront them. Hacking gave us a start. We knew from the hysteria our fun had created, and from the new government legislation, that we had hit upon something fundamental about how secrets were hidden. Governments were scared: much more scared, it turns out, than they were of people demonstrating in the street or throwing petrol bombs over barricades. The Internet would offer a model of insurrection that baffled corrupt authority with plain science. It said, 'You no longer control how I think of you.'

One Australian headline, of 1990, read: 'When sharing your disc can be as dangerous as sharing a needle.' This manages to get information-sharing